It is Never too Late

Chiara Motta Filippo Palomba

Draft available upon request

Abstract. Can technology relax constraints on the supply of education and expand local productive capacity? We study a large-scale expansion of adult education through broadcast television. Between 1960 and 1968, the Italian public broadcaster and the Ministry of Education aired a daily literacy course, "Non è mai troppo tardi" (It is never too late), supported by a national network of collective viewing centers. The intervention used a common broadcast curriculum to extend educational provision across geographically dispersed communities. We exploit terrain-driven differences in television reception, conditional on transmitter placement, and estimate stacked long differences across the 1951, 1961, and 1971 censuses for roughly 7,700 municipalities. A one-standard-deviation increase in signal strength raised adult literacy by 0.18 percentage points during the program decade relative to the preceding decade, equivalent to approximately 17% of the average decadal gain. The estimate is robust to alternative controls, restrictions to small towns, and comparisons between neighboring municipalities sharing the same free-space signal. Improved reception also increased labour-force participation by 1.0 percentage point overall and 1.4 percentage points among women, shifted employment out of agriculture. Labor-market responses extended to neighboring municipalities within approximately 15 kilometres, consistent with effects operating across local labour markets. Literacy gains were larger in initially less literate municipalities and in places with collective viewing centers, suggesting that broadcast technology and local delivery infrastructure jointly shaped the reach of the intervention. Our findings suggest that expanding educational supply through communication technology can increase adult skills and support structural transformation, with economic benefits extending beyond the locations directly exposed.

Chiara Motta | cmotta@berkeley.edu | chimotta.github.io